

ON THE TRAIL OF TROPICAL FRUIT

*Exploring the Manatee Rare Fruit Council's
collection at Palma Sola Botanical Park*



John Coletti/The Image Bank

Above: Palma Sola Botanical Park, near Bradenton, Fla., showcases collections of various palms as well as fruiting and flowering trees. Its walking paths take visitors on an exploration of the plants that ring serene water features.

ROADSIDE SIGNS or advertisements of any other kind that have descriptors like “botanical” or “horticultural” in conjunction with words like “garden,” “plantation,” “nursery” or “arboretum” will draw me to the highlighted setting like a

bee to goldenrod. I have been known to drive great distances to satisfy my curiosity about all things that grow.

While in Florida last winter, I did not have to travel very far at all to find the tropical fruit collection at the unassuming little gem called

Palma Sola Botanical Park (PSBP), with which I had become familiar while ferrying small busloads of grandchildren to their favorite tree-top playground in Manatee County’s Robinson Preserve. My curiosity regarding “rare” tropical fruits has

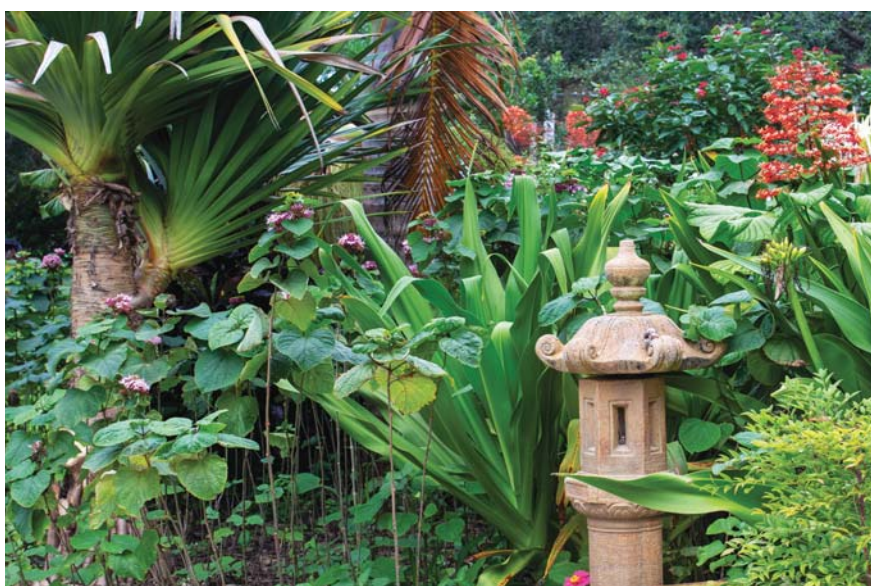
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been piqued by the relatively recent establishment of Caribbean and Latin American food markets near my Rhode Island home. Visiting these, I almost always come across a fruit or vegetable that I cannot identify or have not yet sampled.

One day I introduced myself to PSBP's very helpful and informative Beverly Burdette, Executive Director, who filled me in on local history and the establishment of the park. She acquainted me with Peter Robertson, current President of the Manatee Rare Fruit Council, which presides over the well-regarded fruit collection located on site. Peter had answers for all my questions about the challenges of growing so many varieties of tropical fruits.

I read about the Palma Sola area, located near Bradenton, Fla., in a local publication for tourists. It was named after a solitary date palm—in Spanish, a *palma sola*—that stood out to early post-Civil War settlers of the area, who were largely from New England. From the outset this area was observed to have a localized microclimate (though the term was not used back then) that allowed for the growing of plants usually seen in the tropics. At the latitude of 27.5 degrees north, the Bradenton locale is some 4 degrees (about 280 miles) away from the actual tropics that lie between the Tropic of Cancer and Tropic of Capricorn.

Until the early 1990s, Manatee County had been using what is now the ten-acre botanical garden site as its palm tree nursery. When the parcel was declared surplus land, local citizens, community groups and the *Bradenton Herald* lobbied to preserve it as green space or for a park. In 1993, the Palma Sola Botanical Park Foundation was established and later joined with the Manatee County government to formally create the present park.



Top to bottom: Ornamental flowering plants like Florida native perfumed spider lily (*Hymenocallis latifolia*) also delight guests at Palma Sola Botanical Park. A stone lantern echoes the shape of pagoda flowers (*Clerodendrum paniculatum*) blooming alongside a path.

THE FRUIT COLLECTION

Working individually and through organizations, growers in many suitable Florida locations have begun to promote the establishment of tropical-fruit collections that can provide interested parties with once difficult-to-obtain information regarding their cultivation and use.

And so it was that the Manatee Rare Fruit Council (MRFC) came to be hosted at PSBP, the result of a 2005 proposal by Julie McClure, a park

board member. Julie worked with Ray Jones, the founder of MRFC, and Pete Ray, a council member, to develop a project plan, recognizing that a lot of time-consuming site preparation would be needed to bring the dream to fruition.

The stated objectives of the MRFC are “to introduce, propagate and distribute the many rare tropical and sub-tropical fruits grown throughout the world; to educate its members and the public as to the



merits of these plants; to encourage and extend their cultivation.” With clearly expressed goals and a tabula rasa at PSBP, the council planted its first trees in 2008, concurrent with the creation of a shell path that more or less parallels the perimeter of a small, tranquil pond. The county then installed an irrigation system, which uses treated wastewater, an important accommodation for ensuring the survival of the immature trees and bushes that would be donated or purchased for the project. Seeing how the specimens have flourished validates this maintenance decision.

The MRFC began as a subsidiary of Rare Fruit Council International of Miami, which itself had been established in 1955. By 2014, MRFC became an independent entity, successfully expanding its tree collection as it raised funds by selling tropical fruiting stock of all types at an annual sale that has attracted buyers now for some 36 years. According to Pete Robertson, the Manatee Council has about 100 members who make the magic happen, organize and attend lectures and contribute their own grown items to be sold.

The MRFC website lists about 60 trees imported from around our planet’s warmest locations in its collection, many of which the casual visitor may classify as “exotic.” A leisurely stroll through the grounds provides a wealth of information about each of the specimens. A garden feature that I particularly like at Palma Sola is the low-tech but highly detailed signage that answers most questions a visitor will have: *Where is this fruit from? How is it eaten? What does it taste like? When is its season?* And so on. I’ve visited far too many beautiful gardens that only relate plant information via QR codes or by a number corresponding to a description in a pamphlet. More often than one would expect, people



Top: Detailed signs put the facts about the collection’s holdings front and center. **Above:** Papayas dangle beneath a Florida February sky. **Right:** This tree is in the midst of propagation by air layering.





A NEW FRUIT SALAD

Here are a few of the lesser-known fruiting plants that caught my fancy as I explored the Manatee Rare Fruit Council's collection at Palma Sola Botanical Park on a beautiful, sunny February day. Hopefully you will be teased into visiting this park to see so much more. The setting makes it easy to envision how the trees may fit into your own landscape for fruit production or, in many cases, just for their aesthetic or attention-grabbing value.

Lychee (*Litchi chinensis*) The only member of its genus, it was first introduced into Florida from China and Southeast Asia in the 1930s. The white, fleshy, fragrant, grape-sized fruit is easily removed from a shell. With a very sweet taste, it is usually eaten fresh but lends itself well to drying and canning. I've enjoyed lychee in a simple syrup for dessert many times at Asian restaurants. A 5-year-old tree can produce 500 fruits. Propagation is generally by air layering and the trees do best in a humid climate with abundant rainfall.



Brazilian grape (*Plinia cauliflora*) This Brazil native has the very unusual trait of blooming and producing fruit on its trunk all year long. Fruits are grape-like in size, texture and taste, reminiscent of our muscadine variety of grapes. The dark purple fruit is eaten fresh or made into jams, jellies or wine. The grapes over-ripen quickly, so a large market has not developed for them outside of Brazil.



Jackfruit (*Artocarpus heterophyllus*) Probably native to an area extending from southern India to Borneo, this watermelon-sized fruit in the fig, mulberry and breadfruit family usually makes it to market in the 10- to 50-pound range, but 110-pounders are not unknown! The pebble-skinned jackfruit is the largest tree-borne fruit in the world, mostly eaten raw, although in the unripe state it may be cooked like a vegetable. The pulp is meaty and scented with notes of pineapple and banana. Off-putting to me is the fact that latex from the core of the fruit is so sticky that street vendors sometimes provide a little kerosene for customers to clean their hands after enjoying their treat. The timber from the tree contributes to construction and furniture making, while the wood chips and sawdust are processed into a yellow dye.



Sugar apple (*Annona squamosa*) This is a very weird-looking, round or conical, knobby fruit, usually pale or gray-green in color, that from some angles appears to be an artichoke. Of unknown origin, the tree is widely grown in tropical South America, the West Indies and South Florida. The creamy white, sometimes yellow flesh is sweet and custardlike. Usually one separates the seeds in the mouth and spits them out. The trees rarely grow over 20 feet tall and bear fruit after just two or three years, but yields may be low in Florida because honeybees are not its best pollinators. (Beetles do the job elsewhere.) On small trees, hand pollinating dramatically increases yield.



Black sapote (*Diospyros digyna*) Native to both coasts of Mexico and the Yucatan, this tree made its appearance in the US around 1915. It would be a nice ornamental, with its glossy deep green leaves similar to some of the persimmons that I've grown. However, it may eventually reach to 80 feet. It is in the same genus as persimmons, so the unripe fruit's astringence comes as no great surprise. Outside of Mexico and the Philippines, black sapote, sometimes referred to as "chocolate pudding fruit," has not achieved great popularity. I will seek it out because I like both persimmons and chocolate pudding. — GC



Left to right: Dragon fruit develops on the cactus *Selenicereus undatus*; seeing one at Palma Sola Botanical Park inspired author Greg Coppa to try a dragon fruit from his local grocery store. Pickerelweed blooms pondside at Palma Sola.

can't readily access information provided in this fashion, a situation that can be very frustrating.

Pete told me that one of the few things that surprisingly does not grow at PSBP is citrus. As in many parts of Florida, huanglongbing (HLB) or "citrus greening" disease, has decimated trees and orange orchards in this region. Treatments for the bacterial infection and the development of disease-resistant trees are ongoing. This blight is a very sad development for an area that was renowned for citrus production. It was right in Manatee County that the Reasoner family, acclaimed

for introducing Americans to pink grapefruit as well as to the beautiful royal palm (*Roystonea regia*), kept their esteemed nursery.

What's next for PSBP and MRFC? Pete says that tree plantings will expand. PSBP recently acquired two acres adjacent to the existing MRFC plantings. One acre of this new land will be dedicated to additional tropical pomology. There may even be future opportunities for providing disadvantaged local people with fresh fruit from the mini plantation.

Visiting PSBP and seeing the beautiful cactus (*Selenicereus undatus*) that bears the increasingly

available dragon fruit inspired me to buy and try one. Slices of it tasted something like a kiwi with a hint of pear. In the grocery store where I bought it, I also saw sweet tamarind and lychee-like rambutan. It seems that one of the Manatee Rare Fruit Council's goals—to introduce new tropical fruits to consumers—was achieved with me.

I hope that many more people will visit the wonderful tropical collection at Palma Sola Botanical Park, perhaps taking one of the occasional group tours. The park has so much to offer serious horticulturists and curious visitors alike. ☞



Above: A dwarf banana plant shows Palma Sola visitors just how these familiar fruits develop from the leafy tree's downhanging purple flowers. **Below:** The location's warm microclimate also supports interesting bromeliads, like this *Aechmea blanchetiana* in bloom.

